The Necklace

The big idea

The Necklace by French writer **Guy de Maupassant** tells of **Matilda Loisel**, who loses a borrowed necklace and spends **ten years** in poverty paying for a replacement — only to learn the original was **fake**. It is a story about **pride, vanity and honesty** with a famous twist ending.

Summary

1. **Matilda's discontent:** Matilda is pretty but born into a family of clerks. She is married to **Monsieur Loisel**, a petty **clerk in the Board of Education**. She is unhappy with her simple home and dreams of luxury and wealth.
2. **The invitation:** Loisel brings an invitation to a **ball given by the Minister of Public Instruction**. Instead of being happy, Matilda cries because she has no suitable dress.
3. **The dress:** Loisel gives her **400 francs** that he had saved to buy a **gun** for shooting trips with friends.
4. **The necklace:** She still feels poor without jewels. On her husband's advice she visits her rich school friend **Madame Forestier**, who lets her borrow a beautiful **diamond necklace**.
5. **The ball:** Matilda is the most beautiful woman there; everyone admires her. They leave at **about 4 a.m.**, hurrying away so others won't see her plain wraps.
6. **The loss:** At home she finds the **necklace is gone**. Loisel searches everywhere; they cannot find it.
7. **The replacement:** They find a similar necklace in a shop for **40,000 francs**, which they get for **36,000**. Loisel has **18,000 francs** from his father's

inheritance and **borrows the rest**, signing ruinous promises. They return the necklace to Madame Forestier without telling her.

8. **Ten years of poverty:** They dismiss the maid, move to a cheap attic; Matilda does all the heavy housework and bargains for every sou; Loisel works evenings copying documents. After **ten years** they repay everything. Matilda has become old, coarse and hard.
9. **The twist:** One Sunday on the **Champs Élysées** she meets Madame Forestier, still young and beautiful, and tells her the whole story. Madame Forestier, deeply moved, reveals: **"My necklace was false. It was worth at most 500 francs!"**

TWIST ENDING (IRONY OF SITUATION)

Ten years of suffering were for a fake necklace. If Matilda had been **honest** and told her friend the truth, she could have saved herself.

Characters

Character	Traits
Matilda Loisel	beautiful, vain, dissatisfied, materialistic; later shows courage and hard work
Monsieur Loisel	simple, loving, contented, self-sacrificing husband
Madame Forestier	rich, generous friend

NUMBERS

Dress: **400 francs**. Replacement: **36,000 francs** (asked 40,000). Inheritance: **18,000 francs**. Real necklace: **at most 500 francs**. Time: **10 years**.

Themes and value points

- **Pride and vanity** bring ruin; contentment brings peace.
- **Honesty** is the best policy — one lie led to a decade of misery.
- Appearances can be deceptive (the "diamond" necklace).
- Positive side: Matilda faced her duty with heroism and paid the debt.

LIKELY QUESTIONS

Why was Matilda unhappy? How did Loisel get the money for the dress? What would have happened if she had confessed? What was the twist? Character sketch of Matilda / Loisel.

Quick recap

- Guy de Maupassant; Matilda and Loisel; Madame Forestier.
- Ball invitation → 400-franc dress → borrowed necklace → lost.
- Replacement for 36,000 francs → ten years of hardship.
- The original was fake (worth at most 500 francs).

Practice questions

1. What was Monsieur Loisel's job?
   (a) A banker (b) A jeweller (c) A clerk in the Board of Education (d) A minister
2. Why did Matilda cry when she got the invitation?
   (a) She did not like dancing (b) She had no suitable dress to wear (c) The ball was far away (d) Her husband could not go
3. How much did Loisel give Matilda for the dress?
   (a) 500 francs (b) 36,000 francs (c) 400 francs (d) 18,000 francs
4. For how much did they buy the replacement necklace?
   (a) 40,000 francs (b) 500 francs (c) 18,000 francs (d) 36,000 francs
5. How long did it take the Loisels to repay their debts?
   (a) Ten years (b) Two years (c) Five years (d) Twenty years
6. What did Madame Forestier reveal at the end?
   (a) The necklace was stolen (b) She had found the lost necklace (c) Her necklace was false, worth at most 500 francs (d) She never owned a necklace
7. "Matilda's pride and dishonesty ruined her life." Discuss.

Answers: 1. c 2. b 3. c 4. d 5. a 6. c 7. see notes